

Titles and Meta Descriptions

The highest-leverage two fields on a page, one of which is not a ranking factor at all.

Bottom line

The title tag is the single most impactful on-page element, worth a measured 3.7 positions between optimized and unoptimized. The meta description is not a ranking factor and never has been. It is a CTR lever, and after Section 5 you know that CTR is where a large share of your available traffic now lives.

Two fields, two different jobs

The title tag does two jobs at once. It tells search engines what the page is about, and it is the clickable headline in the results. It affects both whether you rank and whether anyone clicks.

The meta description does one job. It is sales copy under the headline. Google has stated repeatedly it is not a ranking factor. But it influences CTR, and CTR feeds engagement signals, so it matters indirectly and it matters more than it used to.

Getting this distinction right prevents the two classic mistakes: cramming keywords into a meta description as if it ranked, and writing a title that reads well but tells the engine nothing.

Title tags

Length: think pixels, not characters. Google truncates at roughly **600 pixels**, which works out around **50 to 60 characters**. Characters are a proxy because letters are different widths. A title full of capitals and Ms truncates earlier than one full of lowercase Is and Ls. If a title matters, check it in a SERP preview tool rather than counting.

Front-load the primary query in the first 40 characters. Two reasons: it survives truncation, and early terms carry more weight. [practitioner]

Match the format the SERP is rewarding. From Section 4, you already recorded the title shapes on page one. If every result is "Best X for Y (2026)", that is the shape searchers respond to on that query. Match the pattern, then differentiate inside it.

Formulas that hold up

Intent	Pattern
Informational	Primary Query: What It Is and How It Works

Intent	Pattern	
Commercial investigation	Best [thing] for [audience] in 2026 or X vs Y: Which for [use case]	
Transactional	`[Service] in [Location] \	[Brand]`
Comparison	X vs Y vs Z: [dimension] Compared	

One title, one page, one intent. If your title tries to serve two intents, it serves neither.

Why Google rewrites your titles, and what to do

Google rewrites titles frequently. How frequently is genuinely contested:

Source conflict, shown rather than averaged. Zyppy measures Google rewriting **61%** of titles. Backlinko measures **76%**. Both are vendor studies with different samples and methods. [practitioner] This is a good live example of the Section 3 grading method. Neither number is authoritative, the honest statement is "roughly two thirds to three quarters", and the useful part is what both agree on.

What both agree on is the cause: Google rewrites when it thinks the title does not represent the page. The common triggers are titles that are too long, keyword-stuffed, boilerplate across many pages, or contradicted by the page's actual content.

The defense is alignment. Your title, your H1, and your first paragraph should tell the same story. When those three agree, Google has no reason to substitute something else. [practitioner]

You cannot prevent rewrites outright, and you should not try to fight one that is producing a better CTR than your original.

Meta descriptions

Not a ranking factor. Say it once more because people keep optimizing it as though it were. No keyword stuffing, no exact-match repetition.

Length: 105 to 155 characters, with the critical information in the **first 120** so it survives mobile truncation. [practitioner]

Write it as an ad, because that is what it is. The searcher has already read your title. The description answers "and what will I get if I click".

What works: a concrete specific, the outcome, and a reason this source is credible. What does not: restating the title, generic phrasing that could describe any page, and marketing language with no content.

Weak: *"We offer comprehensive SEO services to help your business grow online. Contact us today to learn more."*

Better: *"A 60-second triage rubric for deciding which SEO fixes to do first, with the two checks that rule out 80% of traffic drops. Includes the Search Console report to run."*

The second one tells you what is in the page.

Google rewrites descriptions even more often than titles, frequently pulling a passage from the page that better matches the query. That is not a failure. It often produces a more relevant snippet than a static description could. Write a good description anyway, because it is the default and it is what you control.

Where to leave it blank: almost nowhere, but a generic auto-generated description is worse than none, because Google will pull a relevant passage instead. If you cannot write a specific one, do not write a bad one.

The CTR connection

Section 5 established that mid-page rankings hold most of your untapped traffic, and that moving position 8 to position 4 is roughly 400% more clicks. Titles and descriptions are how you capture more of the clicks available at your current position, without ranking better at all.

This is the fastest measurable win in SEO. Find pages with high impressions and low CTR, rewrite the title and description, and watch the CTR column. No new content, no links, no waiting for a core update.

Testing what actually happened

Rewriting is not the end. Verify.

- 1 Search the query and look at what Google displays.** Did it keep your title?
- 2 Check Search Console, Performance, filtered to that page.** Compare CTR for the 28 days before and after. Give it at least two weeks.
- 3 If the CTR dropped,** revert or try a different angle. This is one of the few genuinely fast feedback loops in SEO.

Why this matters

most sites have titles written once, at publication, by someone thinking about the CMS rather than the SERP. It is common to find pages ranking on page one with a 1% CTR because the title reads like a filing label. That is free traffic sitting unclaimed, and it takes minutes per page to claim.

Do this now

- 1 Open Search Console, Performance, last 3 months, Pages tab.** Sort by impressions.
- 2 Find 10 pages with high impressions and below-average CTR.** Your site average is the comparison point, shown at the top of the report.
- 3 For each, search the primary query** and look at your result against the competition. Would you click yours?
- 4 Rewrite all 10 titles.** Primary query in the first 40 characters, under 600 pixels, matching the format the SERP rewards.
- 5 Rewrite all 10 meta descriptions.** 105 to 155 characters, specific, key information in the first 120.
- 6 Check title, H1 and first paragraph agree** on each page. Fix any that do not.
- 7 Publish, then record the date and current CTR for each.**
- 8 In two weeks, check which titles Google kept** and how CTR moved. Note the pattern in what got rewritten.

Capstone step

Your ten highest-impression underperforming pages now have titles and descriptions written for the SERP rather than the CMS, with a dated CTR baseline for each. This is usually the fastest visible improvement in the whole course.

Key takeaways

- The title tag is the highest-leverage on-page element, worth a measured 3.7 positions. The meta description is not a ranking factor and is pure CTR.
- Think in pixels, roughly 600, and front-load the primary query in the first 40 characters.
- Google rewrites somewhere between 61% and 76% of titles depending on whose study you read. Alignment between title, H1 and first paragraph is the defense.
- High impressions with low CTR is free traffic sitting unclaimed. Rewriting captures it without ranking a single position better.